



Inform Systems. Transform Lives.

COMMUNITY RESPONSE GUIDE

Mandated reporters play a key role in protecting our children and communities. However, when mandated reporters refer families to child protective services (CPS) for needs that aren't related to abuse and neglect, missed opportunities and unintended consequences can occur. Families receive more government oversight and intervention than may be warranted, and the limited resources of CPS may be directed in ways they shouldn't be. Finally, more referrals can mean that families who desperately need intervention for child abuse and neglect concerns are overlooked.

In some cases, community-based supports and services may be able to meet families' needs, helping families thrive and stabilize without unnecessary referrals into the system. To solve these problems, it is critical to improve decision making for mandated reporter and CPS hotline staff. The Community Response Guide can help.

FIXING THE FRONT DOOR OF THE CHILD WELFARE SYSTEM

Evident Change's Community Response Guide helps agencies and communities collaboratively develop accurate and fair reporting standards tailored to their state laws and specific needs. The public, online guide includes decision trees for neglect or abuse concerns. When appropriate, it also connects children and families to local support services that may be better suited to address their needs. The result is a real-time decision aid that helps reporters and concerned community members understand and consider the range of local options to help families.

The result? Families who need CPS intervention will

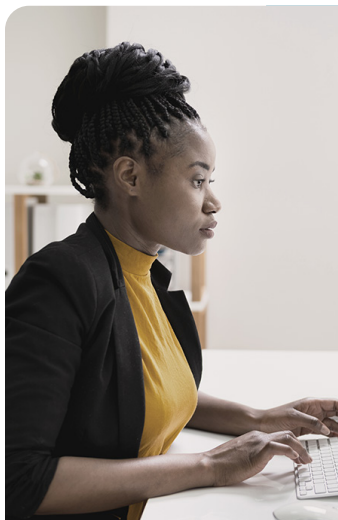


receive it, but families who have unmet non-child welfare needs are directed to local community organizations for support with self-reliance.

By fixing the front door, we all benefit.

- CPS agencies receive the most appropriate reports and respond efficiently.
- More families stay together.
- Families in need receive support without unnecessary intervention, encouraging self-sufficiency and with reduced government involvement.
- Reporters have clear support for their decisions.
- Communities understand their responsibility for supporting their members and are empowered to do so when appropriate, without unnecessary entries into the CPS system.

COMMUNITY RESPONSE GUIDE DEVELOPMENT



LEARN MORE

Evident Change has created community response guides in agencies in the United States and abroad. We can help your agency and community develop and implement a customized guide to support reporting responsibilities.

To discuss a guide for your community, contact Heather Meitner, Director of Family and Community Engagement Strategies, at (800) 306-6223 or via email at HMeitner@EvidentChange.org.